Defying Gravity

By Jane Anderson

Suggested Roles:

ACTRESS 1: *Radio Announcer, Elizabeth, NASA voice on the Radio 2,*
ACTRESS 2: *Teacher (aka Elizabeth's Mom), NASA voice on the Radio 1, TV Newscaster, CB, Grandmother's echo, Beachcomber*

NOTE: This cutting asks each student to portray multiple characters, which is permissible for Nationals and SOME states. It may not meet the rules requirement for DUO in your state! Be sure to check your STATE rules before performing at local tournaments.

RADIO ANNOUNCER: (Pg 12) The Discovery touched down today after a successful 13-day mission. The six crew members had a special guest on board. Ariadne the Spider, who successfully spun a web in zero-gravity. Way to go, Ariadne. In January of next year they plan to send a teacher into space. You're listening to K-FARM 101, easy listening for the Dakotas.

INTRODUCTION

ACTRESS 1: *On January 28, 1986, NASA and the American people were rocked as tragedy unfolded 73 seconds into the flight of Space Shuttle Challenger's mission.*
ACTRESS 2: *An explosion – the result of a leak that ignited the main liquid fuel tank – instantly killed the seven-man crew.*
ACTRESS 1: *Among the dead was Christa McAuliffe, a gifted teacher who could communicate with students from space.*
ACTRESS 2: *It is in part because of the excitement over McAuliffe's presence on the Challenger that the accident had such a significant impact on the nation.*
ACTRESS 1: *But the public record can't begin to describe the personal stories behind the headlines.*
ACTRESS 2: *Defying Gravity by Jane Anderson re-imagines the tragedy from the point of view of Elizabeth, the teacher's daughter, who lost her mother at the age of 5.*
TOGETHER: *Defying Gravity by Jane Anderson*

(Teacher is standing in front audience aka her class, teaching about the Cathedral of Rouen)

TEACHER: (Pg 14-15) Heather, would you change the slide? . . . All the towns were competing with each other to see who could build the tallest cathedral. For a long time, you could only build to a certain height before the pull of gravity would cause the whole thing to collapse. But then they invented

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the flying buttress *(beat)* Butt, very funny, Jason. I broadened the base of the cathedral so the walls could rise hundreds of feet into the air. People always believed if you defied gravity, you were that much closer to God. *(gesturing to the slide)* If you follow the lines of the pillars up, you are led to what many people thought was heaven. Before the airplane, this was the closest that we ever came to the experience of flight. *(beat)* Do you think it was worth it? *(beat)* Anyone?

*****Scene*****

ELIZABETH: (Pg 23-25) *(as an adult)* That Christmas, I asked my mother for a Cabbage Patch Doll But she didn't have time to get me one. All the presents that year were from the NASA gift shop: *(holds up a toy space shuttle)* A plastic space shuttle and a package of astronaut ice cream. My mother was going to read me ***How the Grinch Stole Christmas*** but she kept getting phone calls. *(Elizabeth morphs into her 5-year-old self and begins banging the space shuttle on the floor)*

TEACHER: *(into phone)* Well, as I've been telling everyone, I'm more nervous about getting in the car and driving on the freeway. It's a chance in a lifetime. *(Elizabeth throws the shuttle at the Teacher who dodges)* Can I call you back? *(hangs up, then to Elizabeth)* What's gotten into you? *(phone rings and the Teacher answers)*

ELIZABETH: *(as an adult)* I hated the shuttle. I hated space. I think at that moment, I hated her.

TEACHER: *(into phone)* Well, as I've been telling everyone . . .

TEACHER and ELIZABETH: I'm more nervous about getting in the car and driving on the freeway.

TEACHER: It's a chance in a lifetime.

ELIABETH: It's a chance in a lifetime. . . *(long beat)* **(Pg 9-10)** The last time I saw my mother was in a visiting room next to the launch pad at Cape Canaveral. I remember we got there very early in the morning. They had donuts and hot chocolate waiting for us. Reporters kept coming in. I asked my father if we were waiting for my mother to come back from space. He said that she hadn't even left yet. Then my grandmother gave me a coloring book and a new box of crayons to keep me busy. I broke the point on the blue crayon and I started to cry. *(gets down on the floor as a 5-year old coloring with crayons)*

TEACHER: (Pg 9) All right, Honey, time for bed. Would you put your crayons away, please?

ELIABETH: See what I did? *(Elizabeth shows a piece of paper filled with crayon scribbles)*

TEACHER: I see, that's very pretty

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ELIZABETH: You know what it is? – It's an impressed painting. You know, from the book. The painting in the book.

TEACHER: Oh, you mean Impressionist?

ELIZABETH: Yeah. Guess what it is?

TEACHER: Honey, that's wonderful. Is it a flower garden?

ELIZABETH: No.

TEACHER: Water lilies?

ELIZABETH: Noooo. It's spaghetti!

TEACHER: Ohhhh. I see. Come on, kiddo, it's time for bed.

*******Scene*******

ELIZABETH: (Pg 38) *(as an adult)* I remember a reporter asked me what I thought of my mother going into space. I didn't want to answer so I hid my face behind my grandmother's purse. My brother laughed at me so I hit him on the arm. My grandmother gave us Lifesavers to quiet us down. I put it in my pocket for later. Then my mother joined us and she let me hold her hand while she talked to the reporters. She showed the reporters some of the things she was taking up to space. She had a journal and in the journal was a bookmark that I made for her. I had drawn a rocket and stars and Saturn with the rings and I ironed it between two pieces of wax paper so it would be protected from the gamma rays. I wanted to give her something else, so I took out the Lifesaver. It was fuzzy from the lining of my pocket. While my mother and the reporters talked, I tried to make the Lifesaver presentable. I told myself I had to pick all the lint off the Lifesaver or my mother wouldn't come back. Finally, my mother crouched down next to me. She was wearing her blue space suit. I touched the patches on her shoulders. She looked so beautiful. Suddenly I couldn't grasp that this was the woman who every morning sliced banana on my granola. My grandmother kept saying, "say good-bye, honey, say good-bye to your mother." But all I could manage was to hold out the Lifesaver which was sticky from the sweat of my hand. My mother took it and put it in her pocket and I knew everything would be all right.

NASA VOICE ON RADIO 1: (Pg 39) . . . T-minus thirty minutes and counting.

******On the shuttle*******

TEACHER: (Pg 39) *(to audience as if they were the crew, holding up the Elizabeth's bookmark)* Did you see this? My little girl made it for me. *(looks at it proudly)* Oh my God, I didn't see that. She

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wrote her name. I've been trying to help her learn it, but she said she couldn't because I gave her a name with too many letters in it.

NASA VOICE ON RADIO 2: . . . T-minus 15 seconds and counting / no unexpected errors.

TEACHER: *(distraught)* I need to see her. I need to see my little girl. *(the bookmark slips out of the Teachers hand and falls to the floor)*

NASA VOICE ON RADIO 1: **(Pg 41)** 10, 9, 8, 7, 6, 5, 4, 3, 2, 1 . . and lift off. Challenger, go with throttle up.

ELIZABETH: **(Pg 34)** *(as a child)* MOMMEEE! GIVE ME BACK MY MOMMY! *(sobbing, then an explosion)*

******Scene*******

ELIZABETH: **(Pg 53)** *(as an adult)* When I watched my mother's ship take off, I saw it go straight into the sky and disappear. When my grandmother told me that my mother went to heaven, I thought that was a part of outer space. I was excited because I thought she'd come back with all kinds of neat presents like a plastic harp or a pair of angel wings. I went to the mailbox everyday looking for a postcard from her that would have clouds or a 3D picture of God.

TEACHER: **(Pg 15)** *(echoing)* People always believed if you defied gravity, you were that much closer to God.

ELIZABETH: **(Pg 53)** I waited for her to call long distance. When I didn't hear from her I got very angry. I told my father I hated her for being away so long. He told me she had "perished" in the rocket. I told him that wasn't true, that she was alive.

TV NEWSCASTER: *(voice over)* Reports today from NASA have given us new evidence on the Shuttle disaster. The cockpit has been recovered and the bodies have been found.

ELIZABETH: That she had left us and found a family she liked better. He asked me why did I think she was still alive. And I said, "because I never saw her dead."

CB (MEMBER OF NASA GROUND CREW): **(Pg 46-47)** At T minus nine minutes they couldn't get the handle off one of the hatches. They had to get this special drill. But someone used it and didn't bother to replace the batteries. Let me explain. See, I borrowed the drill to fix the door on my van. I stuck a note on it saying to change the batteries. But I guess the post-it didn't stay on. I should of just changed the batteries myself, but in order to do that I would have had to fill out a form explaining why I needed the new batteries and then I'd have to run it over to another building to get it approved, then wait an hour to have it processed, then run to another building to pick the

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batteries up. Then I would have had to get a guy to supervise me while I put the batteries in. *(beat)* I was at the end of a 20 hour shift and my next shift was in 5 hours. So . . . I'm sorry. I never meant to take your mommy away from you.

TEACHER: (Pg 65-66) *(softly)* Gravity is the force that pulls us towards the center of the Earth.

NASA VOICE ON RADIO 2: . . . T-minus 10, 9, 8 . . .

TEACHER: There is also another definition of gravity: Graveness or seriousness; solemnity, heaviness.

ELIZABETH: (Pg 53) [But I knew none of this.] These are the reasons I gave myself for why my mother didn't come back. ***One:*** I hit my brother on the arm. ***Two:*** I didn't say thank you to my grandmother for the coloring book.

GRANDMOTHER: (Pg 38) *(echoing)* "Say good-bye, honey, say good-bye to your mother."

ELIZABETH: (Pg 53) And ***Three***: I didn't get all the lint off the Lifesaver.

BEACH COMBER: (Pg 48-49) Honey, what is that? Maybe it's a piece of the shuttle. Oh, my god, let's see. *(examines it)* Huh. No, it isn't anything. It's just a . . . .

ELIZABETH: (Pg 53) Lifesaver. *(beat)* I didn't get all the lint off the Lifesaver.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

2003 National Qualifier
2004 National Qualifier
2007 National Qualifier
2013 National Qualifier
2015 National Qualifier
2016 National Qualifier - MS
2023 National Qualifier
NIETOC
CO State Qualifier
IL State Qualifier